Lesson 22: Pronunciation: Voiced and Unvoiced Consonants

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 2: Getting to Know You

Adapted from Speaking, Listening and Pronunciation Projects for ELLs - Intermediate Level by Brittany Zemlick, Grossmont College (CC BY 4.0): Voiced and Unvoiced Consonants.

In this lesson

You will learn the difference between voiced and unvoiced consonant sounds. You will hear and say word pairs like "price" and "prize", where only the final sound is different. You will also learn that a vowel sounds longer before a voiced final consonant.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Feel the difference between voiced and unvoiced sounds with your hand on your throat.
- Say if the final sound of a word is voiced or unvoiced.
- Make the vowel longer before a voiced final consonant (prize) and shorter before an unvoiced one (price).
- Hear and say word pairs such as seat and seed, buck and bug, peace and peas.
- Find voiced and unvoiced final sounds in real English.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
consonant	a sound that is not a vowel	/b/, /p/, /d/, /t/, /s/, /z/
vowel sound	a sound like a, e, i, o, u; vowel sounds are always voiced	play, go, die, knee
voiced	you feel a vibration in your throat when you say it	/v/ as in "leave"
unvoiced	no vibration, only air	/θ/ as in "thumb"
vibration	movement or buzzing that you can feel	Put your hand on your throat. Do you feel a vibration?
final sound	the last sound of a word (not the last letter)	The final sound of "price" is /s/, not the letter "e".
long / short vowel sound	here: the vowel takes more time / less time to say	The vowel in "robe" is longer than the vowel in "rope".

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
word pair	two words that are the same except for one sound	price / prize
buck	(informal) a dollar	He gave me a buck!
bug	an insect	He gave me a bug!
prize	something you get when you win	Did you see the prize?
peas	small, round, green vegetables	We need peas.

Rules and explanations

Voiced and unvoiced sounds

- Put your hand on your throat and say a sound.
- **Voiced:** you feel a vibration (movement or buzzing).
- **Unvoiced:** you feel nothing. Only air comes out.
- Many consonants come in pairs. Your mouth does the same thing, but one sound is unvoiced and one is voiced. Example: /f/ as in "leaf" (unvoiced) and /v/ as in "leave" (voiced).
- Look at the **sound**, not the spelling. "Price" ends with the letter "e", but the final sound is /s/.

Rule 1: Vowels are longer before voiced final consonants

Only the final sound is different in these pairs. Play the clip **Rules_to_Remember_1.m4a** and listen to the vowel.

Final consonant is unvoiced (shorter vowel)	Final consonant is voiced (longer vowel)
rope	robe
coat	code
pick	pig
leaf	leave
price	prize

- Say the vowel before a voiced consonant long and clear: "prize" sounds like "priiize".
- Say the vowel before an unvoiced consonant shorter: "price".
- This is important because many words are the same except for the final sound. If the vowel length is wrong, the listener may hear a different word.

Rule 2: Vowel sounds are always voiced

"Play", "go", "die" and "knee" all end with a vowel sound. Put your hand on your throat: you feel a vibration. Vowel sounds are always voiced.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic has /b/ but no /p/, so /p/ and /b/ are easy to mix up. Practice these pairs carefully: rope / robe, lap / lab, cap / cab. - Arabic has /f/ but no /v/. Make /v/ voiced (feel the vibration): leaf / leave, proof / prove.

Practice

The audio clips for this lesson are in the folder E:\personal-tutor\materials\library\esl-b1-speaking\attachments\02.06-voiced-and-unvoiced-consonants\ and on the original web page (link at the end).

1. Voiced or unvoiced? Write "voiced" or "unvoiced". Use your hand on your throat. Example: The "th" in "thumb": unvoiced.

1. The "th" in "mother"
2. The "b" in "bag"
3. The "p" in "pack"
4. The "d" in "ride"
5. The "t" in "right"
6. The "ng" in "singing"
7. The "y" in "yacht"
8. The "s" in "sea"
9. The "z" in "zoo"
10. The "l" in "let"
11. The "r" in "read"
12. The "h" in "home"

2. Long or short vowel sound? Play the clip **Practice_-*Long_or_Show_Vowel_Sound%3F*.m4a**. Do you hear a long or a short vowel? Circle the word you hear. Then say: which word in each pair has the longer vowel?

1. lap / lab 2. seat / seed 3. coat / code 4. rack / rag 5. buck / bug 6. tack / tag 7. leaf / leave 8. proof / prove 9. peace / peas 10. price / prize

3. Choose the correct reply. Play the clip **Voiced_or_unvoiced_-_choose_the_corrects_reply.m4a**. In each number, do you hear sentence a or b? Choose the correct reply. Then practice with your tutor: you say a or b, and the tutor gives the reply. If the reply does not match, say your sentence again.

	Sentence	Replies
1	a. Did you see the price? b. Did you see the prize?	Yes! It's very expensive! / Yes! Congratulations on winning!
2	a. He gave me a buck! b. He gave me a bug!	He gave you a dollar? Why? / He gave you an insect? Why?

	Sentence	Replies
3	a. We need peace. b. We need peas.	Yes. War is bad for everyone. / Ok. I will go to the store.
4	a. Can you get me a rack? b. Can you get me a rag?	Do you want something to hang clothes on? / Why? Do you need to clean something?
5	a. Get him a seat. b. Get him a seed.	Does he need to sit down? / What is he planting? Fruit or vegetables?
6	a. He bought a pick. b. He bought a pig.	Does he play the guitar? / Why did he buy an animal?

4. Picture dictionary. The book has four photos. Match each word (pick, rag, rack, seed) with a photo:

1. an orange guitar pick and guitar strings
2. a hand cleaning a car with a yellow cloth
3. two hands holding small, round, black things that you plant
4. a frame with hangers and clothes hanging on it

5. Notice sounds in real-world English. Watch Andy's interview (link below). Turn on the subtitles (CC). Find at least 3 words with a voiced final consonant and 3 words with an unvoiced final consonant. Write them in two lists. Examples: voiced: name; unvoiced: ask.

6. More practice 1. Is the final sound of each word voiced or unvoiced?

1. brother 2. farm 3. vegan 4. habitat 5. practice 6. pick 7. office 8. want 9. go 10. play 11. avoid 12. weed 13. water 14. repair 15. hurt 16. listen 17. vegetable 18. work 19. cook 20. drive 21. pull 22. podcast

7. More practice 2. Is the final consonant of each word voiced or unvoiced?

1. lap 2. etch 3. lab 4. rag 5. seat 6. seed 7. rack 8. cab 9. back 10. edge 11. bag 12. cap 13. leaf 14. art 15. brother 16. turn 17. exude 18. park 19. divide 20. device

8. Recording. Read the 12 sentences of exercise 3 (1a, 1b, 2a, 2b ...). Make the vowel before a voiced consonant long and clear, and the vowel before an unvoiced consonant shorter. Record yourself with your phone, listen back, and record again.

Speak with your tutor

- "I will say one word from each pair: lap or lab, seat or seed, buck or bug, peace or peas, price or prize. Tell me which word you heard. If you are not sure, tell me."
- "Let's play a game. I will say 'Did you see the price?' or 'Did you see the prize?' and other sentences from my lesson. Give me the matching reply."
- "Give me ten short English words, one at a time. I will say if the final sound is voiced or unvoiced. Correct me."
- "Ask me what I bought at the store this week. I will try to make my vowels long before voiced final sounds, like 'bag', 'peas' and 'bread'."

Read aloud

- a. Did you see the price? (↗) b. Did you see the prize? (↗)
- a. He gave me a buck! (↘) b. He gave me a bug! (↘)
- a. We need peace. (↘) b. We need peas. (↘)
- a. Can you get me a rack? (↗) b. Can you get me a rag? (↗)
- a. Get him a seat. (↘) b. Get him a seed. (↘)
- a. He bought a pick. (↘) b. He bought a pig. (↘)

Watch online

- Accent Diet video about voiced and unvoiced consonants: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=sJ4lGwE3ja8
- Andy's interview (for exercise 5; turn on CC): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Wa0582oOYgY
- The original lesson page, with the audio clips: https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/Book%3A_Speaking_Listening_and_Pronunciation_Projects_for_ELLs_-_Intermediate_Level_(Zemlick)/02%3A_Getting_to_Know_You/2.06%3A_Voiced_and_Unvoiced_Consonants
- The Interactive American IPA Chart (click a sound to hear it): https://americanipachart.com/

Answer key

1. 1 voiced, 2 voiced, 3 unvoiced, 4 voiced, 5 unvoiced, 6 voiced, 7 voiced, 8 unvoiced, 9 voiced, 10 voiced, 11 voiced, 12 unvoiced. The consonant pairs (unvoiced / voiced): /p/ pack / /b/ bag; /t/ right / /d/ ride; /k/ pick / /g/ pig; /f/ leaf / /v/ leave; /θ/ thumb / /ð/ mother; /s/ sea / /z/ zoo; /ʃ/ she / /ʒ/ measure; /ʧ/ etch / /ʤ/ edge. Always voiced: /m/ as in "home", /n/ as in "knee", /ŋ/ as in "singing", /l/ as in "let", /r/ as in "read", /w/ as in "we", and the "y" sound as in "yacht". Unvoiced: /h/ as in "home".

2. (book) Words in the clip: 1 lap, 2 seed, 3 code, 4 rack, 5 buck, 6 tag, 7 leave, 8 proof, 9 peace, 10 prize. The longer vowel is in the second word of each pair, because it ends in a voiced consonant: lab, seed, code, rag, bug, tag, leave, prove, peas, prize.

3. (book) Sentences in the clip: 1 a. Did you see the price? (Yes! It's very expensive!) 2 a. He gave me a buck! (He gave you a dollar? Why?) 3 b. We need peas. (Ok. I will go to the store.) 4 b. Can you get me a rag? (Why? Do you need to clean something?) 5 a. Get him a seat. (Does he need to sit down?) 6 b. He bought a pig. (Why did he buy an animal?) For practice with your tutor: in every number, sentence a goes with the first reply and sentence b with the second reply.

4. 1 pick, 2 rag, 3 seed, 4 rack.

5. (example answer) Voiced: name, job, car, vegan. Unvoiced: ask, like, eat, meat.

6. (book) 1 voiced, 2 voiced, 3 voiced, 4 unvoiced, 5 unvoiced, 6 unvoiced, 7 unvoiced, 8 unvoiced, 9 voiced, 10 voiced, 11 voiced, 12 voiced, 13 voiced, 14 voiced, 15 unvoiced, 16 voiced, 17 voiced, 18 unvoiced, 19 unvoiced, 20 voiced, 21 voiced, 22 unvoiced.

7. (book) 1 unvoiced, 2 unvoiced, 3 voiced, 4 voiced, 5 unvoiced, 6 voiced, 7 unvoiced, 8 voiced, 9 unvoiced, 10 voiced, 11 voiced, 12 unvoiced, 13 unvoiced, 14 unvoiced, 15 voiced, 16 voiced, 17 voiced, 18 unvoiced, 19 voiced, 20 unvoiced. (The book prints "device" as "divice".)

8. Listen to your recording. Can you hear the difference in each pair? If not, make the vowel in the b sentence longer.

My notes